Capture the Moment

writer
AHLIYAH LUNA

graphic design
SRAVYA NIMMAGADDA

these photos are us, in love, spanning time.

Billy pushes Layla off his lap. "I was making it fun," she protests, but he's already irritated.

Take 2: In love. Layla presses a kiss on his forehead. Billy jerks back, frustrated. He reiterates that they are husbands and wives who are in love and don't touch each other.
Take 3: His face grows even stiffer, his lips tight together in an awkward attempt at neutrality.

Layla, meanwhile, hovers somewhere between confusion and reluctant compliance. Her eyes betray a resigned blackness while he remains hollow and accusatory.

"These photos are us, in love, spanning time," Billy insists. But the strip collapses under the weight of its artifice; they are strangers, and the strip is as raw as they are uncomfortable.

God bless Anatol Josepho, the inventor of the Photomaton. Step inside. Draw the curtain closed. Free yourself from unwanted eyes. A stool meant for one, but you scoot over, making room for someone you admire.

Knees brush, shoulders touch —1…2…3— smile. But hold onto the five-dollar bill for now. Shift a little to your left so my right can catch the lens at a perfect 35-degree angle. Move closer—forward, just a bit—and drop your head.

Enough that your eyes tilt downward and let the light skim the bags under them. Enough to make even the sharpest hunter pause in awe of their gleam.

I'll tilt my head, too. Or maybe just scrunch my nose. Smile? No, don't smile. I'll smile. You stay serious.

Sit up a little straighter so my head fits perfectly against your shoulder. We'll look like a couple. The thought makes me giggle, though now I'm suddenly shy. And you're getting mad because I'm not cooperating. I'm sorry. You tilt your head and smile; I'll stay on my side and be serious.

Go ahead, scroll through your phone, and search for the perfect sequence of poses—something worth five dollars, at least. Never mind the line forming outside the curtain.

Capture the moment... and the exhausting pursuit of a picture perfect lie.

Even this has been reduced to something contrived. I'm sure Anatol didn't envision the thirty-minute wait. His photo booth—a marvel of simplicity and convenience—has been co-opted by our obsession with curated authenticity and performative aesthetics.

I've often admired photos shared online: couples gazing at each other with theatrical devotion, friends clutching each other's faces like they hold the world in their palms. I might also mean films like Amélie (2001) or Falling in Love (1984), where love is born through the grainy intimacy of a photo booth. Or perhaps those awkward, yet endearing, encounters of a first date immortalized in four imperfect frames.

But just as easily, it could be another false advertisement—love on display. And maybe it's not as serious as I make it seem. After all, they're just actors behind the screen. Still, I want to believe in sincerity. The sanctity of the booth. Sharing a single stool is as intimate as it gets, stopping just short of becoming overly sentimental or weird.

And if you're alone? What could be more personal than capturing nothing but yourself in that tiny, curtained space? But after fifteen seconds of slashing light—preceded by half an hour of rehearsals, fraying the patience of those in line—I am transported back to grade school.

Tears well in my eyes as I stand before a woman barking orders from behind the camera as she positions me for my ID picture.
And maybe this whole ordeal was only ever meant to be some low-budget homage to Buffalo '66 (1998).

"No bullshit faces—no funny faces. Just look like you like me," Billy says to Layla. So, here I am, off your lap, playing the part, pretending I don't like you as much. I won't smile. I won't tilt my head. I won't move even an inch closer to your face. So please, as you see fit, take something that once stood as a symbol of vulnerability and turn it into yet another tool for societal scrutiny.

Then again, I'm just bitter—bitter because I wanted this to be fun. I won't settle for snapshots without souls, for projecting a life we want others to believe in but devoid of honesty.

This is nothing more than an empty ritual, stripped of joy and drained of any sort of fondness.

I am in a claustrophobic theater, watching a stale, obligatory performance, leaving nothing but the residue
of compulsory participation.

Click.

Turn your head to the right.

Click.

Shift to the left.

Click.

Lean slightly forward, eyes straight ahead.

Click.

I glance left; you glance right.

Ladies and gentlemen, now presenting from its metallic cage:

our 15 seconds on film.

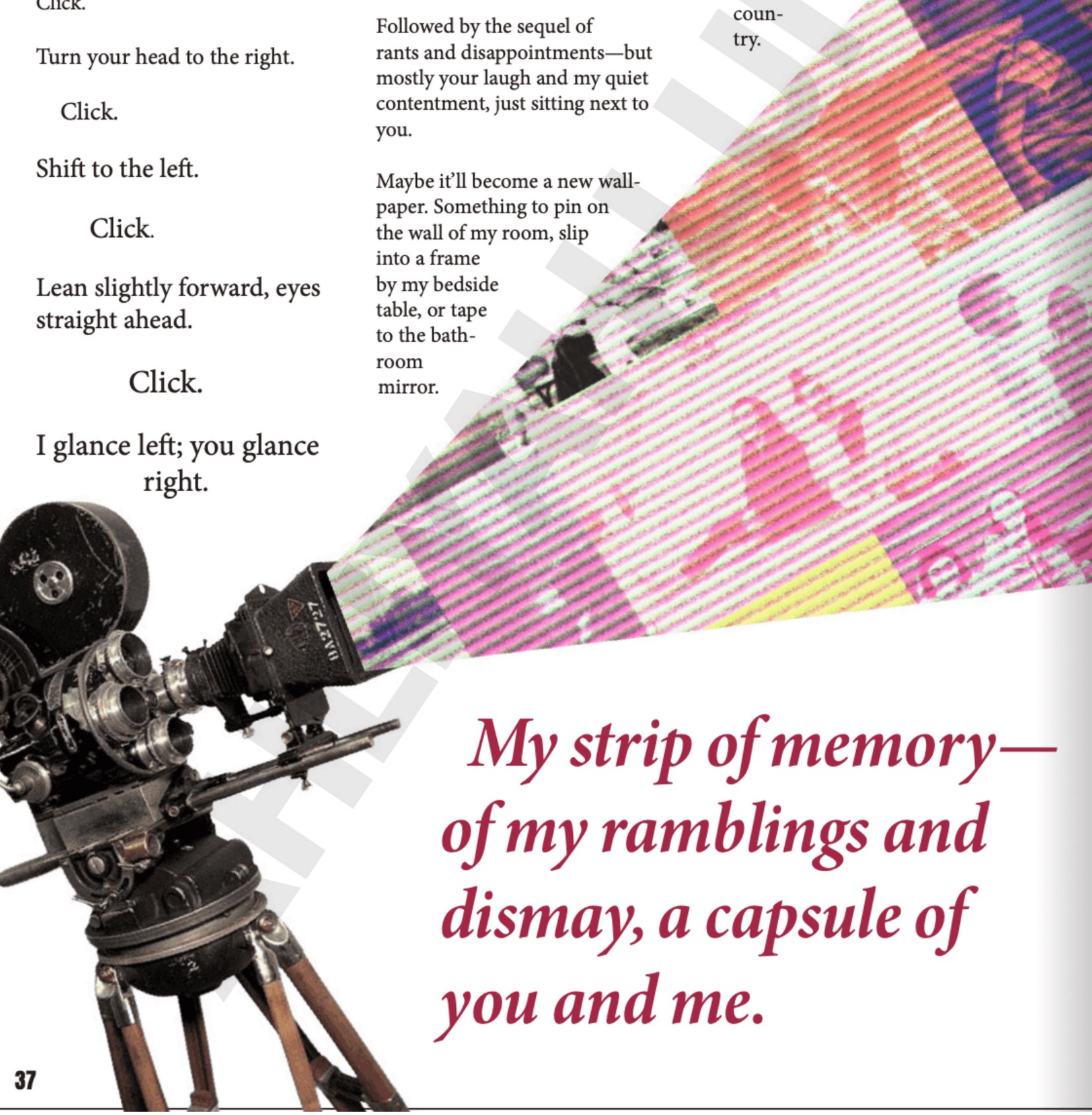
The glossy strip slides out in silence; its slow reveal met with exchanged glances and a knowing snicker. We're dressed in black, and our heads float in a black-and-white void.

Followed by the sequel of rants and disappointments—but mostly your laugh and my quiet contentment, just sitting next to you.

Maybe it'll become a new wallpaper. Something to pin on the wall of my room, slip into a frame by my bedside table, or tape to the bathroom mirror.

It'll sit next to the mileage log in my car or be tucked into the sun visor to shield me from the blazing sun.

Or perhaps a bookmark, nestled between the pages of my favorite prose and carried to a distant country.



My strip of memory—of my ramblings and dismay, a capsule of you and me.